

Trial-Based Cognitive Therapy (TBCT) · Research Study

Getting Ready for Your Eighth Guided AI Session

A short guide to read before you begin

This guide explains what will happen in your eighth session with the AI assistant. Reading it first means you'll know what to expect, why the session is shaped the way it is, and how to get the most out of it. It takes just a few minutes to read.

Welcome back — from two sides talking to a full hearing

In your last session you sat with a decision you felt torn about, and let the two sides of you — Emotion and Reason — speak to each other while a third, quieter side listened. You saw how giving each part its own voice, and its own chair, could ease an inner tug-of-war that words alone had left stuck.

This session uses that same idea of stepping into different parts of yourself, but turns it toward something deeper than a single decision: one of the harsh, sweeping judgements many of us quietly carry about who we are. “I am a failure.” “I am unlovable.” “I am not good enough.” Beliefs like these can sit underneath a great many everyday troubles, rarely said out loud and almost never given a fair hearing. This session gives one of them exactly that — a fair hearing — through a method called Trial One, also known as the Trial-Based Thought Record. You'll put the belief on trial in an imaginary courtroom, and step into each of the roles a real trial would need.

Good to know: There are no right or wrong answers here, and nothing you say is being graded. The aim is not to “win” the trial, or to argue yourself into feeling good — it is to give a belief you've long treated as plain fact the fair examination it has never had, and to see what it looks like once you do. Whatever verdict you reach is yours.

What this session is

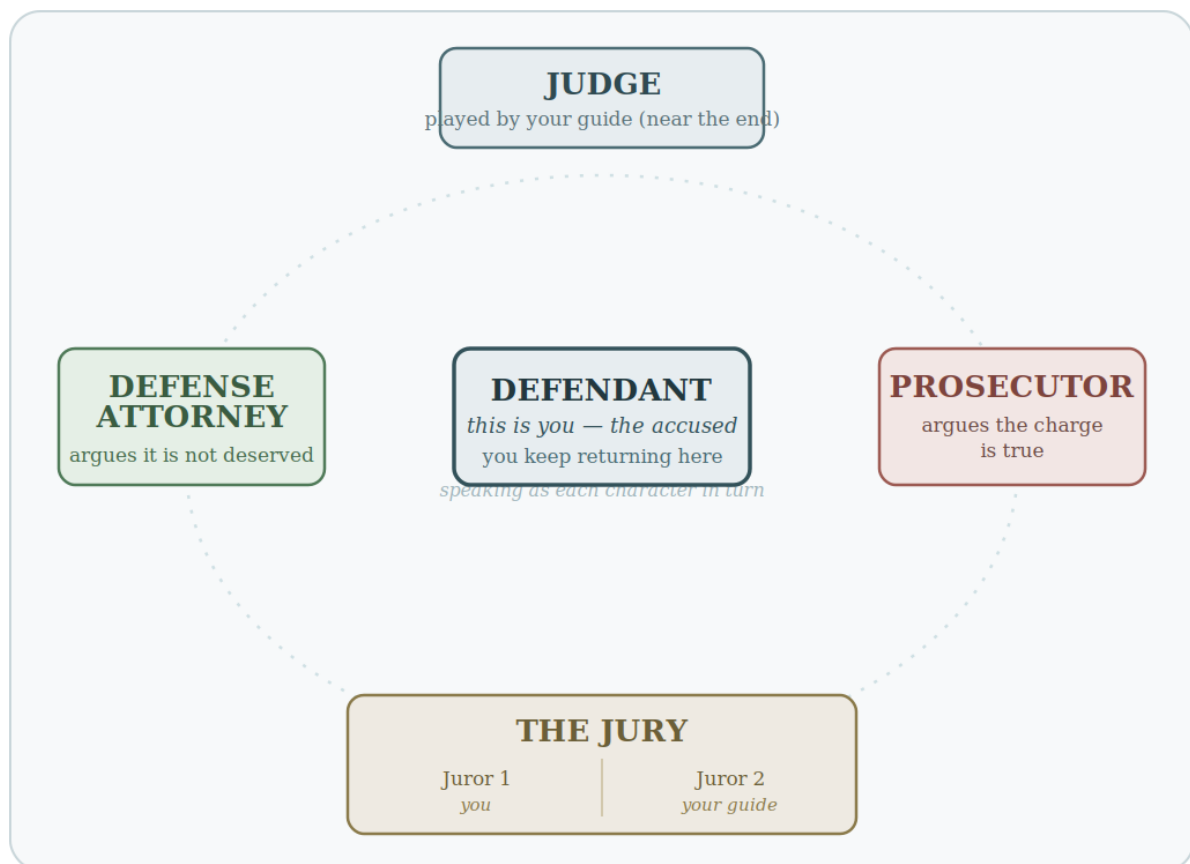
You'll work through one main tool with the AI guide: Trial One, a structured way of examining a painful belief about yourself as though it were a formal accusation in a court of law. Together you'll take one such belief — a “charge” — and try it properly: hearing the case against it, the case for you, the challenges to that case, and finally an impartial verdict.

The unusual part, and the part worth knowing in advance, is that you play every role yourself, one at a time. You'll be the defendant — yourself, the accused; then the prosecutor, who argues the charge is true; then the defense attorney, who argues it isn't deserved; and finally a juror, weighing the evidence. You'll move between chairs — or, in a text session, the guide will mark each move in words — and in each chair you speak as that character, not as yourself.

The point is the examination, not the verdict. Most people arrive believing the charge almost completely and leave believing it far less — but that shift is something you notice for yourself, never a target to hit. A belief looked at fairly and still half-believed has already loosened its grip.

You'll never be argued with. The guide won't take the prosecutor's side or the defense's, won't supply your evidence, your ratings, or your verdict, and won't tell you what to conclude. Its job is to set the courtroom up, move you gently between the chairs, and then, mostly, stay out of the way.

Here is the courtroom you'll be working in — the chairs you'll move between, and who sits where. Don't worry about taking it in fully now; the guide will walk you into each chair when the time comes.



The Trial One courtroom, seen from above. You begin in the defendant's chair and keep returning to it; in turn you also become the prosecutor, the defense attorney, and — with the guide as a second juror — a member of the jury. The guide plays the judge only near the very end. Copyright © Irismar Reis de Oliveira; trial-basedcognitivetherapy.com.

Who you'll be talking to

As before, you'll be chatting with an AI assistant set up to guide this one exercise — a friendly companion for this particular step. A few things to keep in mind:

- **It is not a replacement** for your therapist or doctor. It's guiding one exercise, not managing your overall care.
- **It won't take sides.** It won't argue that the charge is true or false, won't favour the prosecutor or the defense, and won't step in as one of your characters — apart from playing the judge for a moment near the end.
- **It won't put words in your mouth.** Every piece of evidence, every rating, and above all the verdict comes from you. The guide will never supply them.
- **It won't rush you.** You can move slowly, ask to pause, or continue another day — the trial is long, and it doesn't have to be finished in one sitting.
- **It stays gently focused** on this exercise. If you raise something else, it will kindly keep to the task and suggest saving that for your therapist.

How the session will flow

The session moves through a clear, unhurried sequence. You don't need to memorise it — the guide leads the way — but here's the shape, so nothing feels out of the blue.

A quick word first — the belief as a charge

Before anything else, the guide will explain the idea underneath the whole method: that a harsh belief about yourself works rather like an accusation you've been carrying without ever getting to answer it. We tend to treat “I am a failure” as a plain fact, not as a claim that could be examined and tested. Putting it on trial is simply a way of finally examining it — with all the fairness a real court would demand. It's a short orientation, not a lecture, and you'll be asked what you make of it before moving on.

Part 1 — Finding the charge

You'll start with one real, specific situation that upset you, and the thought that went through your mind. Then the guide will gently follow that thought downward — “if that were true, what would it mean about you?” — one step at a time, until it reaches the deeper belief sitting underneath. That belief, put into a few plain words, becomes the charge for the trial. The guide will then ask how much you believe it, from 0 to 100%, which emotion it stirs, and how strong that feeling is — your starting figures, noted down and tracked all the way through.

The situation is only the trigger. You might wonder why the work moves from the upsetting moment to a belief about your whole self. It's because the single situation is just the spark; the belief is the deeper accusation you carry across your life — and that is the thing worth examining. The situation isn't forgotten, though: its facts often turn into useful evidence later on.

Part 2 — Taking your seat as the defendant

The guide will introduce the courtroom and the four roles you'll step into, then invite you into the first chair — the defendant's, which is simply you, the person the charge is about. Every time you change chairs, the move is made slowly and clearly: the guide names the role you're leaving and the one you're entering, and waits until you feel settled before carrying on. From the defendant's chair, you'll be asked once more how much you believe the charge, and how strong the feeling is.

Part 3 — The prosecution

Next you'll look at the empty chair to one side and picture the person who will accuse you — a man or a woman, their age, their face, their manner — until you can see them clearly. Then, with a clear, unhurried change of chairs, you become the prosecutor, and from that chair you make the case that the charge is true, one piece of evidence at a time.

A stranger, not someone you love. The prosecutor should be an imagined figure — perhaps a stern lawyer you invent — and never someone close to you, such as a parent, partner, or friend. If a real loved one comes to mind, the guide will gently help you picture a more neutral figure instead. (People who matter to you can be looked at another time, in a different exercise.)

Let the prosecutor be unfair. In this chair you may find yourself saying sweeping, harsh, or not-quite-logical things. That isn't a mistake — it is exactly what's meant to happen. Getting those accusations out into the open, in someone else's voice, is what lets you examine them clearly later.

Part 4 — The defense

Back in the defendant's chair, you'll hear the prosecution's case read aloud, and rate the charge again. Then you'll picture a second figure in the opposite chair — this time someone wise and kind, though again not anyone you actually know — and become your defense attorney. From that chair you'll bring evidence that you don't deserve the charge, drawing on real, concrete examples from across your life, not only the situation you started with.

Real examples, not kind words. A good defense doesn't lean on “he's a lovely person” or “she tries hard.” It brings facts — things that were actually done, said, or achieved. If your defense drifts into vague praise, the guide will gently ask for a concrete example instead; and if it slips into criticising the defendant, the guide will quietly ask whether that's really the defense speaking. You can also swap in a more confident defense attorney if the first one struggles to find its footing.

Part 5 — The rebuttal, and the reply

Real trials go back and forth, and so does this one. You'll return to the prosecutor's chair, and the guide will read each piece of the defense's evidence followed by an emphatic “but...” — leaving you to complete the prosecution's challenge to it. Then, back as the defense attorney, you'll answer: for each piece of your evidence, you'll say what it means about the defendant and then, after the word “therefore...,” where that leads. Each time you return to the defendant's chair in between, you'll rate the charge and the feeling again, and watch how the numbers move.

Speaking in role. Whenever you're the prosecutor, the defense attorney, or a juror, you speak to the court about the defendant in the third person — “she has...,” “he did...” — rather than “I.” If an “I” slips out, the guide will gently point it out; it's just a small sign you've stepped back into being the defendant, and easy to reset.

Part 6 — The jury

Now you and the guide become the two jurors and move to a private jury room — a space no one else may enter: not the prosecutor, the defense, the judge, or even the defendant. Together you'll go back through every piece of evidence, one at a time. For the prosecution's material, the guide will ask what you make of each piece — and you'll often find that what sounded damning is really a distortion: a harsh label, a leap to a conclusion, an all-or-nothing judgement. For the defense's material, you'll check that each piece is solid and true. Then the jury reaches its verdict: guilty, or not guilty.

Why “not guilty” is the usual outcome. It isn't a trick, and it isn't the guide steering you. It's what tends to happen when a belief like this is examined fairly: the case against you turns out to be built mostly of distortions, while the case for you is built of facts. A short list of the distortions the jury looks for is in the Annex, so they feel familiar when they come up.

Part 7 — After the verdict, and the appeal

Once the verdict is announced — you'll stand and read it aloud to the judge, a role the guide steps into just for this moment — you return to the defendant's chair and rate the charge and the feeling one last time. Then the guide asks the question that opens the way forward: if the defense and the jury were right, what does that say about you? Your answer, in your own words — something like “I

am capable,” “I am enough” — becomes a new, more truthful belief. And because a belief like that grows only with evidence, you'll begin a simple daily record, the Preparation for the Appeal, noting small things each day that confirm it.

The appeal is the real homework. The prosecutor rarely gives up quietly, and a day or two later the old belief can start arguing its case again. The daily record is how you stay ready — a line or two each day, with a fresh rating — quietly building the evidence that keeps the new belief standing. It's the part that carries the work of the trial into the rest of your life.

Closing — before and after

To finish, the guide sets your very first ratings beside your closing ones — how much you believed the charge, and how strong the feeling was, at the start and now — and marks, warmly, whatever has changed.

A worked example

Seeing a finished one can make the path clearer. Here is Trial One followed through for a neutral, everyday example — someone who, after a work project went badly, found themselves believing “I am a failure.” Yours will be about your own belief, in your own words, and the numbers you reach will be your own.

The charge, in the person's words: *“I am a failure.”*

- **The prosecution** argued that the person was disorganised, had let the team down, and never really finished anything properly.
- **The defense** brought facts: the project had in the end been delivered, only late; two colleagues had asked for their help that same month; they had finished a training course in the spring.
- **The rebuttal and reply** went back and forth — “the project was late, but it was delivered, which means she can carry hard things through; therefore she is capable” — and with each round the belief eased a little more.
- **The jury** found the prosecution's case was made almost entirely of distortions — labelling, all-or-nothing thinking, discounting the positives — while the defense's evidence held up as true. The verdict: not guilty.
- **The appeal** began that same evening, with three small entries under a new belief, “I am capable,” and a first rating of how much it was believed.

Stage of the trial	Belief in the charge	Emotion (sadness)
At the start (the charge is set)	100%	100%
After hearing the defense	70%	70%
After the prosecution's rebuttal	85%	85%
After the defense's reply	40%	30%
After the jury's verdict	10%	10%
After the first appeal entries	0%	—

A note on the numbers. There's no target here — no particular percentage to reach, and no required “not guilty.” This person's belief happened to fall a long way; another person's might move less, and that would be just as real a result. Notice, too, that the figure can rise for a stretch — as it does here during the prosecution's rebuttal — before settling. What matters is the fair hearing, not the size of the drop.

What the conversation will feel like

- **Lots of gentle questions.** The guide leads mostly by asking, not lecturing — the insights land better when they're yours.
- **One step at a time.** It completes and confirms each part before the next, and moves you clearly between chairs, so nothing piles up.
- **Unhurried, and pausable.** There's no clock. The trial is long, and you're free to stop at a natural point and continue another day.
- **Okay to be unsure.** If a rating feels like it's between two numbers, just say so — the guide will help you weigh it.
- **Mostly out of the way.** In the chairs, the guide keeps its own voice small, stepping in only to move you along or to invite a character to say a little more.
- **Conversational.** It's meant to feel like talking with a knowledgeable friend, not filling in a form.

What to have ready before you start

- **The Trial One worksheet and appeal form.** Both are in the Annex at the end of this guide — have them open or nearby. The guide will check you have them before you begin.
- **One real but manageable belief.** A harsh belief about yourself that genuinely troubles you — real, but, as before, not the very heaviest thing you carry. A moderate one works best for learning the method, and you can bring harder ones to your therapist.
- **A specific situation to start from.** One particular moment that stirred the belief gives the trial somewhere concrete to begin.
- **Two or three chairs, if you can — or just a spot to shift.** Being able to physically move between the roles helps the method work, but it works in words alone if that's easier.
- **A quiet stretch of time.** Ideally uninterrupted — and it's perfectly fine to plan for more than one sitting.
- **An open, curious frame of mind.** You're here to give a belief a fair hearing — not to judge yourself, and not to force a happy ending.

A few tips to get the most from it

- Answer honestly — the trial only reflects what you put into it.
- Let the prosecutor be as harsh and sweeping as it wants. Giving those accusations a clear voice is the whole point, not a slip.
- For the defense, reach for facts over compliments — one concrete thing you actually did is worth more than any amount of “I'm a good person.”

- Stay in role: while you're the prosecutor, defense, or juror, speak about the defendant as “he” or “she,” not “I.”
- Don't rush the jury. Looking at each piece of evidence on its own is where the shift usually happens.
- Keep going with the appeal record afterwards — the daily habit is what makes the change last — and, if you can, share your finished worksheet with your therapist.

What this session is not

So there are no surprises, here's what the AI won't do:

- It won't diagnose you or manage your treatment.
- It won't provide crisis support or emergency care.
- It won't argue for or against the charge, or decide the verdict for you.
- It won't put a real loved one in the prosecutor's or the defense's chair — those figures stay imaginary here.
- It won't push you to finish in one sitting, or to reach any particular result.

If you're in distress. This session is a learning exercise, not an emergency service. Looking closely at a painful belief about yourself can stir strong feelings. If at any point you feel overwhelmed, or you have thoughts of harming yourself, please pause and reach out to your study clinician or your local emergency services right away. Your safety matters more than finishing the exercise.

You don't need to prepare anything else — the AI will guide you step by step. When you're ready, begin whenever you like.

Annex

The four roles, at a glance

Keep this nearby during your session. In each role but the defendant's, you speak to the court about the defendant in the third person — “he” or “she” — never “I.”

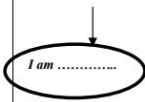
Role	Who they are, and what they do
Defendant	You — the person the charge is about. You return to this chair after each stage to rate how much you believe the charge and how strong the feeling is.
Prosecutor	An imagined, neutral figure who argues the charge is true, drawing on evidence from across your life. Never someone close to you.
Defense attorney	An imagined, wise and kind figure who argues you don't deserve the charge, using real, concrete examples. Also never anyone you actually know.
Juror	The impartial part of you — with the guide as a second juror — who weighs each piece of evidence, spots the distortions, and reaches the verdict.

Your Trial One worksheet

This is the same worksheet your guide works from, column by column. You don't have to fill anything in beforehand — it's here so the shape feels familiar, and the guide will display it as you go.

Table 4. TBCT Form (Trial I).

Please, briefly describe the situation:

1. Inquiry/Establishing the accusation (core belief). What was going through your mind before you started to feel this way? Ask yourself what these thoughts meant about yourself, supposing they were true. The answer “If these thoughts were true, it means I am a ...” is the uncovered self-accusation (core belief).	2. Prosecutor's plea. Please, state all the evidence you have that supports the accusation/core belief that you have circled in column 1.	3. Defense attorney's plea: Please, state all the evidence you have that does not support the accusation/core belief that you have circled in column 1.	4. Prosecutor's rebuttal to the defendant's plea. Please, state the thoughts that question, discount, or disqualify each piece of positive evidence in column 3, usually expressed as “yes, but...” thoughts.	5. Defense attorney's rejoinder to the prosecutor's plea. Please, after reading each thought of column 4, add the conjunction BUT , and then provide the meaning about you. <i>Note: columns 5 and 6 are filled in at the same time.</i>	6. Conclusion about the meaning. Please, state your conclusion after the conjunction therefore .	7. Juror's verdict. Please, report cognitive distortions made by the prosecutor and the defense attorney and give the verdict.																												
Downward arrow technique: <i>If the thoughts above were true, what would they mean about you?</i> 	1) 2) 3) 4) 5) 6)	1) 2) 3) 4) 5) 6)	But: 1) 2) 3) 4) 5) 6)	Meaning: 1) 2) 3) 4) 5) 6)	Therefore: 1) 2) 3) 4) 5) 6)	Cognitive distortions: <table border="1"> <tr> <th>Prosecutor 1</th><th>Defense 1</th></tr> <tr><td>1 -</td><td>1 -</td></tr> <tr><td>2 -</td><td>2 -</td></tr> <tr><td>3 -</td><td>3 -</td></tr> <tr><td>4 -</td><td>4 -</td></tr> <tr><td>5 -</td><td>5 -</td></tr> <tr><td>6 -</td><td>6 -</td></tr> </table> <table border="1"> <tr> <th>Prosecutor 2</th><th>Defense 2</th></tr> <tr><td>1 -</td><td>1 -</td></tr> <tr><td>2 -</td><td>2 -</td></tr> <tr><td>3 -</td><td>3 -</td></tr> <tr><td>4 -</td><td>4 -</td></tr> <tr><td>5 -</td><td>5 -</td></tr> <tr><td>6 -</td><td>6 -</td></tr> </table> Verdict:	Prosecutor 1	Defense 1	1 -	1 -	2 -	2 -	3 -	3 -	4 -	4 -	5 -	5 -	6 -	6 -	Prosecutor 2	Defense 2	1 -	1 -	2 -	2 -	3 -	3 -	4 -	4 -	5 -	5 -	6 -	6 -
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The Trial One worksheet (TBCT Form). The columns run left to right through the trial: the charge, the prosecutor's plea, the defense attorney's plea, the prosecutor's rebuttal, the defense attorney's reply and its meaning, and the jurors' verdict — with the belief and emotion ratings recorded beneath each stage. Copyright © Irismar Reis de Oliveira; trial-basedcognitivetherapy.com.

A short list of cognitive distortions

These are the kinds of thinking the jury looks for when weighing the evidence. You don't need to learn them by heart — the guide will ask what you make of each piece of evidence, and having glanced at this list beforehand simply makes the ones that turn up easier to name.

Distortion	What it is	A quick example
Labelling	Pinning a fixed, global label on yourself from a single event.	"I made a mistake, so I'm a failure."
All-or-nothing thinking	Seeing things in two extreme categories, with no middle ground.	"If it isn't perfect, it's worthless."
Discounting the positive	Brushing aside good things as if they don't count.	"They only praised me to be polite."
Mind reading	Assuming you know what others think, without real evidence.	"They all think I'm useless."
Should statements	Holding yourself to rigid rules about how you must be.	"I should have handled that perfectly."
Blaming	Taking on responsibility for things that weren't yours to control.	"It's my fault my sister is unwell."
Overgeneralising	Turning one instance into an "always" or "never."	"I always get everything wrong."
Catastrophising	Predicting the worst and assuming it will be unbearable.	"If I try, it'll be a disaster."
Personalising	Reading others' behaviour or events as being about you.	"They left early because of me."
Magnifying / minimising	Blowing up the negatives and shrinking the positives.	"One slip proves it; my good work means nothing."
Mental filter	Fixing on one detail and missing the whole picture.	"One correction means the whole thing failed."
Unfair comparisons	Measuring yourself against others and coming up short.	"I'm a failure next to her."

Your Preparation for the Appeal record

This is the daily record you'll begin at the end of the session and keep going afterwards. Write the new, positive belief at the top; then, each day, note at least one small thing that supports it, and rate how much you believe it that day. Over time, this is what strengthens the new belief.

Table 5. Preparation for the appeal (One-belief form).

Positive new core belief: I am (Please, write down here at least one piece of evidence supporting the new core belief. Also, write how much you believe it, daily, in the space between parentheses).

Date 1. 2. 3.	(%)	Date 1. 2. 3.	(%)	Date 1. 2. 3.	(%)
Date 1. 2. 3.	(%)	Date 1. 2. 3.	(%)	Date 1. 2. 3.	(%)
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The Preparation for the Appeal form. The positive new core belief goes at the top; each day you add a piece or two of evidence and a fresh rating (%). One piece of evidence may support more than one belief. Copyright © Irismar Reis de Oliveira; trial-basedcognitivetherapy.com.

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